

# Session 14: Burden of Leadership

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## Key Takeaways

- Two conversations with Jethro frame Israel's deliverance story ([Exod. 4](#) and [18](#)).
- Jethro represents the first of many nations who will acknowledge Yahweh's greatness because of his victory over Pharaoh.
- It seems noble of Moses to shoulder the burden of all the people, but it's unwise.

## Exodus 18 in the Literary Design of Exodus

[Exodus 4:18-31](#) and [Exodus 18](#) frame Israel's deliverance story.

- Moses speaks with Jethro ([Exod. 4:18a](#); [18:5-12](#)).
- Jethro offers a blessing of peace ([Exod. 4:18b](#); [18:7](#)).
- Zipporah travels with Moses' sons ([Exod. 4:20](#); [18:6](#)).
- The noun *ḥōtēn*, which can mean father-in-law or other male in-law, appears in both passages ([Exod. 4:18](#); [18:1](#), [7-8](#), [24](#), [27](#)); Zipporah also uses the related noun *ḥātan* ([Exod. 4:25-26](#)), which refers more broadly to a relative by marriage.
- Aaron greets Moses with a kiss at the mountain of God ([Exod. 4:27](#)); Moses greets Jethro with a kiss near the mountain of God ([Exod. 18:5-7](#)).
- Both passages include Aaron and the "elders of Israel" ([Exod. 4:29](#); [18:12](#)).

Note the vague location in [Exodus 18:5](#). This reserves "Sinai" for later so that this incident can participate in the wilderness framing of the Sinai narratives.

## Jethro's Testimony

### Exodus 18:10-11 NIV

<sup>10</sup> Praise be to the LORD, who rescued you from the hand of the Egyptians and of Pharaoh, and who rescued the people from the hand of the Egyptians. <sup>11</sup> Now I know that the LORD is greater than all other gods, for he did this to those who had treated Israel arrogantly.

Jethro's testimony affirms the literary structure of the book: rescue of Moses + rescue of Israel = the nations know YHWH is greater than all gods.

## Exodus 18 in the Literary Design of the Torah

Exodus 18 and Numbers 10-11 frame the Sinai narratives.

- Moses receives advice from a Midianite family member (Exod. 18:17-23; Num. 10:29-31).
- Moses struggles under the burden of leadership (Exod. 18:13-16; Num. 11:10-17).
- Moses appoints elders to share the burden (Exod. 18:24-26; Num. 11:24-25).

Moses' complaint in Numbers 11 echoes Jethro's words from Exodus 18.

#### **Exodus 18:18b** Instructor's Translation

For this thing is too heavy for you; you are unable to do it alone.

כי־כבד ממך הדבר  
לא־תוכל עֲשֹׂהוּ לְבַדְךָ:

#### **Numbers 11:14** Instructor's Translation

I myself am unable alone to carry all this people, for it is too heavy for me.

לֹא־אוּכַל אֲנִי לְבַדִּי  
לְשַׂאת אֶת־כָּל־הָעָם הַזֶּה  
כִּי כבד ממני

### **Reflection Question**

Reflect on Jethro's role in bearing witness to Israel's deliverance and Yahweh's greatness. How do you see this connecting to other biblical themes?